Journal of Jewish Education

ISSN: 1524-4113 (Print) 1554-611X (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/ujje20

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Sharon Avni & Nicole Samuel

To cite this article: Sharon Avni & Nicole Samuel (2025) An Unprecedented Year in Jewish Education and American Jewish Life: Antisemitism on Campus After October 7, 2023, Journal of Jewish Education, 91:2, 103-106, DOI: 10.1080/15244113.2025.2496588

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/15244113.2025.2496588

Published online: 24 Jul 2025.

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JOURNAL OF JEWISH EDUCATION
2025, VOL. 91, NO. 2, 103–106
https://doi.org/10.1080/15244113.2025.2496588

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

EDITOR'S NOTE

An Unprecedented Year in Jewish Education and American Jewish Life: Antisemitism on Campus After October 7, 2023

The October 7, 2023 attack on Israel and Israel's military response in Gaza sent shockwaves through Jewish communities around the world. Almost immediately, American college and university campuses became ground zero as students and faculty members on both sides of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict reacted with grief, fear, and anger. As the Israel-Hamas war intensified, so did tensions on American campuses. Jewish students reported social isolation from their peers, ostracization from student groups, incidences of harassment and intimidation, and being subjected to professors' antisemitic and anti-Israel comments in classes. As public and private universities across the country became the epicenter for protests, encampments, and the occupation of campus buildings, schools took drastic steps, including returning to remote learning, limiting access to campus, canceling classes, and scaling back commencement ceremonies. In some instances, the encampments and counter-demonstrations resulted in physical violence and clashes with law enforcement. As university presidents were called to testify before Congress and created "antisemitism task forces," they struggled to draw the line between protecting free speech and ensuring a safe living and learning environment.

Seeing these tensions play out on their own universities, on social media, and in the traditional news, the editorial board of the *Journal of Jewish Education* decided in early June 2024 to devote a special issue to antisemitism and anti-Zionism on American college campuses. It was clear to all involved in this decision that the turmoil on campuses had implications for Jewish education and American Jewish life more broadly. This issue, which was fast tracked to respond to a host of events, many of which were happening as authors were conducting their research and writing their pieces, is dedicated to capturing this extraordinary moment in American Jewish life. This issue also represents the first time the journal has published a special issue dedicated to contemporary antisemitism, which in itself is a statement about the profound socio-cultural changes impacting American Jewry.

When we agreed to serve as guest coeditors of this special issue in summer 2024, we had a sense that this project would find a receptive audience. However, we had no way of knowing how many submissions to expect or if there were even enough scholars actively studying this topic to fill an entire special issue. Much to our surprise, we received more than one dozen proposals, along with a handful of inquiries from scholars involved in studies on antisemitism on campuses outside the United States. What was even more

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unanticipated was that the topic of antisemitism on American college campuses connected scholars from a range of disciplinary backgrounds. While receiving a robust response to a call for papers for a special issue is typically greeted with delight (along with some degree of relief), we would be remiss not to acknowledge our conflicted feelings about the "success" of this issue. The number of articles selected for this issue (seven in total) reflects the extent to which antisemitism on campuses has become a notable issue in Jewish education and underscores the extent to which this topic has become a core component of American Jewish life. As various stakeholders debate the definition of antisemitism and decry its weaponization, this special issue makes an important contribution to advancing our understanding of the forms and stakes of anti-Jewish hatred at this inflection point of American Jewish life.

Expanding on a growing subfield of research on American Jewish students' experiences in the aftermath of the October 7th attack (e.g., Hersh and Lyss, September 2024; Wright et al., December 2023 and April 2024; Samuel et al., December 2024), the qualitative and quantitative studies included in this issue center the experiences of Jewish students on American university and college campuses. However, the focus on students is by no means exhaustive. Other focal areas that may draw future scholarly attention include faculty, graduate students, alumni, donors, parents of current students, student affinity groups, professional organizations, Jewish organizations (both on and off campus), admissions and acceptance processes, classroom interactions about Jewish and Israel-related topics, and course curricula.

The first two articles in this special issue attend to definitional categories of antisemitism. In "What Crosses the Line? Understanding the Boundaries of Antisemitism and Criticism of Israel Through the Perspectives of Jewish College Students", Sasha Volodarksy, Graham Wright, Shahar Hecht, and Leonard Saxe use survey research to understand how Jewish undergraduates perceive antisemitism and distinguish it from criticism of Israel. The authors take a "bottom up" approach to defining what constitutes antisemitism and focus on the views of the broader population, in this case, Jewish college students on campus in 2023–2024, rather than relying on definitions created by groups of experts disconnected from the campus experience. Providing important data indicating that students widely perceived certain statements critical of Israel as antisemitic, this study makes a vital contribution to understanding how Jewish students experienced the campus environment after October 7.

In "Making the Invisible Visible: A Taxonomy of Contemporary Antisemitic Experiences on College Campuses", Yael Silverstein and Caryn Block create a classification system for experiences with antisemitism, including microaggressions. Antisemitic microaggressions have been overlooked in the literature to date, and the authors' taxonomy is a critical contribution to the existing research on microaggressions and discrimination against minority groups. The authors find that both overt and subtle experiences of antisemitism cause psychological stress

and can affect Jewish community members' sense of belonging and commitment to their college or university. The study underscores the importance of recognizing antisemitic microaggressions and the detrimental impact of these incidents on mental health and sense of belonging.

In the third article, "Anti-Israelism and the College Campus: The Case of Columbia University", Rebecca Kobrin and Daniella Coen focus on Israeli students at Columbia University and their experiences after October 7. Using student-generated surveys and social media postings to demonstrate how the post–October 7 context at Columbia affected Israeli students' academic lives, psychological well-being, and relationship to the university, this study demonstrates how hostile views of military service in the Israeli Defense Forces and rhetoric about the Israeli military on social media resulted in a distinct form of antisemitism—anti-Israelism, or discrimination against those born in Israel and that hold Israeli nationality.

The fourth article, "Ethical Leadership in the Face of Antisemitism and Anti-Zionism: University Presidents' Responses to the October 7 Hamas Attack", by Julia Ancis and Talia Gruber, adds a new layer to our understanding of the different stakeholders on campus in the immediate days and months following the October 7th attack. Through content analysis of public statements, Ancis and Gruber examine how university presidents navigated their roles as campus and national leaders in the highly polarized and political climate and how university leadership was tested in unprecedented ways to varying degrees of success and failure.

The next two articles offer the texture and nuance of students' voices. Jonathan Krasner, Cheryl Wiener, M. Greenwald, and Lance Rothchild's "Between Home and Homeland: Jewish College Students Confront the Israel-Gaza Conflict and Campus Divides" utilizes in-depth interviews to identify six distinct behavior patterns that show the complexity of students' experiences and Jewish identities in the months after October 7. Vikki Katz, Emma Forman, and Noel McGuire's "Unsettled Ground: How Jewish Undergraduates are Negotiating Identity Shifts and (Un)civil Campus Discourse after October 7" explore how undergraduates realigned or defined their Jewish and political identities after October 7 and how these changes result in the students' decisions to engage in or avoid discussion of topics related to events in the Middle East and antisemitism at home. The authors of both articles found that Jewish students were not a monolith and held different or disaggregated views on Israel, Palestine, and the Israel-Hamas war. They encourage us to consider the implications of students' experiences for Jewish life on campus and for the broader American Jewish community.

Finally, in "Jewish Fraternities and Sororities as Sites of Campus Belonging, Community, and Resistance to Antisemitism", Jenny Small, Pietro Sasso, and Danielle Lund look to spaces on college campuses in which Jewish undergraduates had opportunities to be together and navigate the antisemitism they were

experiencing. Though much of the research presented in this article was collected prior to October 7, Small, Sasso, and Lund show how Greek organizations provide Jewish space outside Hillel and Chabad, which can be critical for helping to insulate students from antisemitism.

This special issue captures an important time in both Jewish education and the American Jewish story, and it is our hope that these articles underscore the urgency of undertaking research that can facilitate nuanced discussions and assist educators, policymakers, and communal leaders in their efforts to address the various forms of Jewish discrimination and hatred.

Disclosure Statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Notes on Contributors

Sharon Avni is Professor of Academic Literacy and Linguistics at CUNY-BMCC.

Nicole Samuel is an associate research scientist at the Cohen Center for Modern Jewish Studies University at Brandeis University, where her work has focused on Jewish young adults, leadership development, and Jewish and Israel education.

Sharon Avni
savni@bmcc.cuny.edu

Nicole Samuel
nsamuel@brandeis.edu